

Archaic Greece

The seventh century BCE saw the beginning of Greek art's Archaic period. Defined through pottery and sculpture, the period also saw the beginnings of democracy, and the re-establishment of written language. Influenced by neighbours such as the Egyptians, the Greeks adopted new styles that replaced the Geometric. The Archaic period (800–480 BCE) was more naturalistic. Paintings on vases represented human figures, often illustrating stories. In sculpture, faces were animated and bodies followed realistic proportions. The developing Doric and Ionic orders of architecture also reflected harmonious proportions.

The Archaic also saw developments in sculpture: using limestone, marble, terracotta, bronze and wood, sculptors created balanced figures, mainly to adorn temples and funerary monuments. Kouroi – life-sized or larger free-standing stone figures of unclothed young men striding forward – are one of the most distinctive products of the period. Korai are their clothed female equivalents.



Marble kouros from Thebes, c.600 BCE